

|1988| THE SATANIC VERSES IS BANNED

In the Twilight Zone

The book sets off a cultural conflict, echoes of which are heard even today

That India, the country of his birth, was the first in the world to ban the controversial novel *The Satanic Verses* "without even reading it", is a grouse iconic novelist Salman Rushdie holds till date. Published on September 25, 1988, it was banned within nine days of its release in the UK by the Rajiv Gandhi government. The initial attacks came from Janata Party MP Syed Shahabuddin who alleged that the book was "a deliberate insult to Islam," and admitted in the same breath that he had "not read the book". Congress MP Khurshid Alam Khan claimed that he agreed with freedom of expression, but not if "it meant that you hurt someone else's feelings." As moderate Muslim Babruddin Tyabji prophetically said, "The less they understand the thrust of the book, the more agitated they will become." In Delhi, the Imam Bukhari of the Jama Masjid thundered that "it would be very difficult for Rushdie to remain alive". Still, unlikely support for Rushdie came from Shiv Sena Supremo Bal Thackeray and the BJP. It just so happened that Iran did not ban the book but the protests in India made the clerics there take note,



PROTESTORS BURNING *THE SATANIC VERSES* IN BRADFORD

leading to the infamous fatwa imposed in February 1989, leaving Ayatollah Khomeini and Rushdie handcuffed to the same page in the history of contemporary literature. The novel was subsequently banned in over a dozen countries, including Pakistan, South Africa, Saudi Arabia and Venezuela. In March 1989, the UK and Iran broke off diplomatic relations over Rushdie. Poet Dom Moraes, Thackeray and Hindustani Andolan convenor Madhu Mehta received death threats for criticising the fatwa. Bookshops stocking the novel in the UK and California were bombed and Rushdie was forced to go into hiding. On December 24, 1990, he even rendered a public apology which went unheard and the fatwa continued to stay in force. In India, it is estimated that over 3,000 copies are smuggled in every year, which makes it more than 60,000 copies in 20 years. The Indian government kept Rushdie away for 10 years by denying him a visa while several agencies in Iran continue to keep the fatwa alive by raising the bounty on his head, sending Rushdie what he calls, a "valentine every now and then."

by Nirmala Ravindran

SHEKHAR GUPTA/www.indiatodayimages.com



COUP LEADER LUTHULI

THE MAIN EVENT

Maldives Coup

At 9 a.m., the Prime Minister presided over a high-level meeting, attended by the three service chiefs. At noon, the Cabinet Committee for Political Affairs okayed military help for Maumoon Abdul Gayoom and a message was flashed to the Paras Brigade in Agra. By the time the Paras, led by Brigadier Farooq Balsara, had begun to plan the operations, naval reconnaissance aircraft were already over the Maldives, sending back pictures of the Hulule airstrip which was to be the paras' launching pad. Within six hours of the Cabinet's approval, the first giant IL-76, carrying two companies of paratroopers along with Brigadier Balsara and Indian High Commissioner Arun Bannerjee, rumbled off from Agra.

India Today, November 30, 1987

ALSO

- Voting age is reduced from 21 to 18 years
- The first test launch of the Prithvi missile is carried out
- An earthquake measuring 6.6 on the Richter Scale shakes Bihar, killing hundreds

World Cup The victory in 1983 brought attention to India and the sport among non-cricket playing nations.

Hotmail Sabeer Bhatia created history when he created a web-based email system in 1996.

Nuclear Tests India made it to the top news across the world for its nuclear tests in 1998.

Mother Teresa She came to India at the age of 18 and founded the Missionaries of Charity.

Amartya Sen was the recipient of the Nobel Prize for his contribution to welfare economics in 1998.